



TARANTULA · THERAPHOSIDAE

Keep your tarantula the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: an enclosure built low so a fall can't kill, water that prevents the most common cause of death, molting read correctly, and the routines that keep a tarantula thriving for a lifespan measured in decades.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every measurement in inches and centimetres, sized to leg span
- ✓ Two pages on molting, the event that ends most tarantulas badly
- ✓ The one controlled housing study, reported honestly, findings and all
- ✓ Rehousing method, urticating hair first aid, and where they're banned

43 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 before buying anything, and read page 28 before you buy the spider. The enclosure decision is the one that kills tarantulas: an enclosure taller than it is wide gives a heavy-bodied spider somewhere to fall from, and a fall ruptures an abdomen. Get the shape right, get the substrate deep, and put a water dish in from day one. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 31.

If your tarantula is already set up

Go to the Setup Checklist on page 29 and audit what you have, paying particular attention to fall height and substrate depth. If your spider has stopped eating, do not panic: go to page 12 first, because in this species a refused meal is usually normal rather than a symptom. If it has a shrivelled abdomen or is sitting with its legs curled beneath it, that is the genuine emergency, and it is page 24.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 29: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 37: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 30: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 38: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 39: Acquisition & Molt Log |
| ☐ Page 34: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 41: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Tarantula keeping is refreshingly simple and unusually easy to get wrong in a few specific ways, most of them invisible until the spider is dead. It is also a hobby with very little veterinary backstop, which puts more weight on husbandry than on treatment. This package sets out what is actually known, including the single controlled housing study on page 21 reported with its unflattering findings intact, cross-checked against the sources listed on page 43.

BUY THE SPECIES, NOT THE LOOK

Ask the seller what the species is, in Latin, and look up its type before you buy the enclosure. "Tarantula" covers animals with genuinely incompatible needs, and a shop selling a fossorial baboon spider in a shallow display tank is not a reliable guide.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An exotics vet who treats invertebrates, where one exists. Many areas simply do not have one, which is the honest situation and the reason this book leans hard on prevention. Find out now whether anyone within reach will see a tarantula, and write it on page 30. Experienced keeper communities are the realistic second line, and they are genuinely useful, but they are not a diagnosis.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Family	Theraphosidae, over 900 species on every continent except Antarctica
Adult size	2 to 12 in (5 to 30 cm) leg span depending on species. A Chilean rose hair sits around 4.5 to 5.5 in (11 to 14 cm)
Lifespan	Females commonly 15 to 20 years or more. Males typically 4 to 7 years total, because they stop molting at maturity
Native range	Tropics and subtropics worldwide. Desert, grassland, rainforest floor, and canopy depending on the species
Diet type	Obligate carnivore, ambush predator, live insect prey only. No formulated diet exists (page 10)
Enclosure minimum	About 3× the leg span in floor width, roughly 20×10×10 in (50×25×25 cm) for an adult, and horizontal
The one hard rule	Keep it low. Height is the danger, floor area is the benefit, and a fall ruptures an abdomen (page 6)
Housing	One per enclosure. Most species are solitary and cannibalistic, and no enclosure size fixes that
Handling	Strictly look, don't touch. The risk runs in both directions (pages 15 and 17)
Legal status	Legal in most of the US, banned in a handful of places. Check page 28 before you buy
Conservation	Varies. Many species are CITES Appendix II, some are Endangered. Buy captive-bred

SECTION 01

Cost overview

A tarantula is arguably the cheapest long-lived exotic pet there is. The commitment is measured in years, not dollars.

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$70 to \$300 for the enclosure, substrate, hide, water dish and tongs, plus \$25 to \$100 for the spider. A Chilean rose hair or curly hair is usually \$20 to \$50, and slings cost less than adults.

Ongoing

\$5 to \$15 a month, essentially all of it feeder insects, so roughly \$60 to \$180 a year. There is no pet insurance for tarantulas and very little routine vet cost.

THE REAL NUMBER TO SIT WITH

Not the money, the years. A female is a 15 to 20 year commitment and sometimes longer, on a budget most pets would spend in a month. This is arguably the cheapest long-lived exotic pet there is, which makes the time commitment the thing to think through properly before buying, rather than the price.

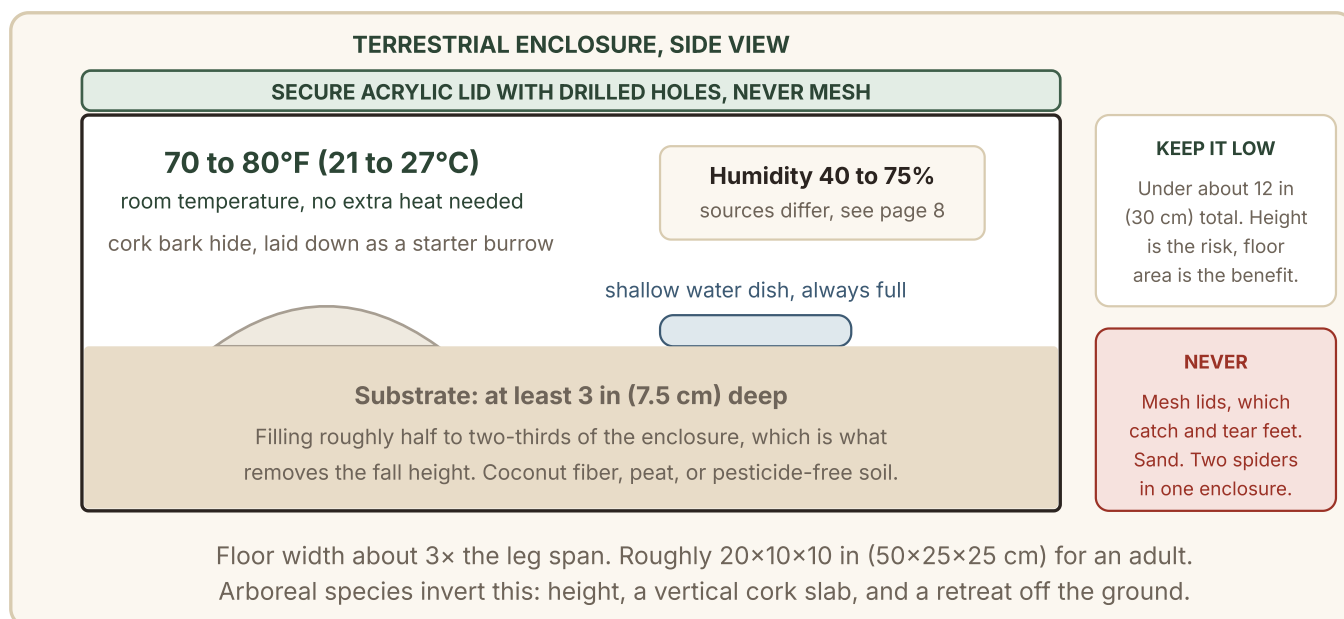
Fun facts worth knowing

- They digest food outside their bodies. A tarantula injects enzymes through its fangs to liquefy the prey's insides, then a muscular sucking stomach pumps the liquid meal in, leaving the empty exoskeleton behind as a small pellet called a bolus.
- Females never stop molting. Most invertebrates stop once they mature; a female tarantula keeps shedding for life, which is a large part of why she outlives a male three or four times over.
- Their blood is not contained. Hemolymph flows freely through the body cavity and bathes the organs directly rather than running in vessels, which is exactly why even a moderate abdominal rupture turns fatal so fast (page 24).

Enclosure: shape, size & the lid

Most commonly kept pet tarantulas are terrestrial, and their enclosure should be **horizontal, wider than it is tall**, specifically to limit how far the spider can fall. A reasonable adult minimum is about 20×10×10 in (50×25×25 cm), roughly a 10-gallon tank, sized to about three times the tarantula's leg span. Keep the overall height low, under about 12 in (30 cm).

That height rule is not fussiness. A tarantula's abdomen ruptures easily and a fall from a height most animals would shrug off can kill it. Everything about terrestrial enclosure design comes back to not letting the spider fall, and the commonest way keepers break it is by filling a tall enclosure only part-way with substrate.



WHERE TO PUT THE ENCLOSURE

Out of direct sun, away from a radiator or a draught, off the floor where it can be knocked, and somewhere with a stable temperature rather than a room that swings overnight. A quiet shelf at eye level is ideal, because you will actually look at the spider, and looking at it is most of the husbandry.

NEVER

Use a mesh top. A tarantula's feet catch in mesh and it can tear off a leg getting free, or hang from it and drop. Acrylic with drilled ventilation holes is the right answer, and it holds humidity better besides.

Substrate, hide & furnishing by type

Get the species type right first. Everything on this page follows from it, and the commonest genuine welfare failure in the hobby is getting it wrong.

Three lifestyles, three setups

TYPE	EXAMPLES	WHAT IT NEEDS
Terrestrial	Chilean rose hair, curly hair, Brazilian black	Wide, low floor. At least 3 in (7.5 cm) of substrate, more if it digs. Cork bark laid flat as a starter burrow. This is the default and the beginner group
Fossorial obligate burrower	Many baboon spiders, <i>Hysterocrates</i>	Deep substrate, 6 to 12 in (15 to 30 cm) or more, packed firm enough to hold a tunnel. Accept that you will rarely see the animal. Keeping one of these on shallow substrate for visibility is the failure this page exists to prevent
Arboreal	<i>Avicularia</i> , <i>Caribena</i> , <i>Poecilotheria</i>	Tall rather than wide, with a vertical cork slab to web a tube retreat against. Cross-ventilation matters more here: stagnant humid air kills arboreals. Substrate still deep enough to hold moisture and cushion a fall

Substrate

Coconut fiber, peat, or organic pesticide-free topsoil, or a mix. All of them hold moisture appropriately and pack well enough to hold a burrow shape without collapsing. Depth is species-dependent, but the floor is 3 in (7.5 cm) and for a terrestrial species filling half to two-thirds of the enclosure is the target, because that is what removes the fall height at the same time.

NEVER USE SAND

It does not hold a burrow, it does not hold moisture usefully, and it is abrasive. Sand appears in tarantula setups because desert species are assumed to want it, and it is wrong for them too: wild "desert" tarantulas live in humid burrows below the dry surface.

Furnishing

A RETREAT

Cork bark round or flat, a half-log, or half a terracotta pot. Laid down for terrestrials, mounted vertically for arboreals. Every tarantula wants somewhere to be out of sight.

LET IT REMODEL

A tarantula that rearranges substrate and webs up an entrance is doing the closest thing to construction this animal does. Don't tidy it back. An enclosure it can't alter is one less thing to do.

LOW STRUCTURE

Cork flats, leaf litter, moss, a low branch, all anchored so nothing can shift onto the spider. Keep it low for terrestrials: structure to move through, not to climb up.

Temperature, humidity & ventilation

The easiest section of tarantula keeping, and the one most often overcomplicated.

Temperature

Room temperature, roughly 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), is fine for most homes and no supplemental heat is needed. If your space genuinely runs cold, use a heat mat mounted on the **side** of the enclosure, never underneath it, paired with a thermostat. A mat under the floor heats the substrate a burrowing spider retreats into to escape heat, which is exactly backwards.

THE HUMIDITY DISAGREEMENT, STATED HONESTLY

Sources genuinely disagree here. Some care guides recommend a moderate 40 to 60% for many commonly kept dry-adapted species, while others, often written from a clinical or exotic-vet perspective, suggest 65 to 75%. This package does not pretend that is settled. What every source agrees on is the practical answer below, which works across the range.

What to actually do

1. Keep a shallow water dish full at all times. This does most of the work and it is the single most important item in the enclosure (page 9).
2. Overflow the dish, or dampen one corner of the substrate, rather than misting the whole enclosure. A moisture gradient lets the spider choose.
3. Mist lightly and rarely, if at all. Heavy misting raises mold risk without a clear benefit, and a soaked enclosure is a worse problem than a dry one.
4. Use a digital thermometer and hygrometer so you are reading numbers rather than guessing, and place the probe at substrate level where the spider lives.

Ventilation

Airflow is the counterweight to humidity and it is what stops mold and mite blooms. Cross-ventilation, meaning holes on opposite sides rather than only in the lid, moves air across the enclosure instead of letting it sit. This matters most for arboreal species, where stagnant humid air is a known killer, and it matters for everyone in a warm room.

If you see mold on the substrate surface, or grain mites appearing around a leftover prey item, the answer is more ventilation and better hygiene rather than a chemical. Both are husbandry problems rather than illnesses (page 25).

Lighting

None required, and none wanted. Most pet tarantulas are nocturnal. Ambient room light on a normal day-night cycle is all they need, and direct sun on an enclosure is a genuine hazard: glass and acrylic cook fast, and a tarantula cannot leave.

Water, and what actually kills tarantulas

This page is one item long, and that item is the most important object in the enclosure.

CHRONIC DEHYDRATION IS THE LEADING PREVENTABLE CAUSE OF DEATH

Not a fall, not a failed molt, not starvation. Dehydration, and it is entirely preventable with a dish of water. Every species, including the arid ones, including slings, including a spider you have never seen drink. Keep it full.

The dish

- Shallow enough that there is no drowning risk. A bottle cap is the standard for a small spider, a jar lid or a small reptile dish for an adult.
- Heavy enough or wide enough not to be tipped over or buried, though a tarantula that buries its dish will do so anyway and you simply dig it out again.
- Changed daily, or at least whenever it has anything in it. Substrate, silk, and prey remains all end up there.
- Plain dechlorinated or bottled water. No vitamins, no additives, and no sponges or cotton wool in the dish, which grow bacteria and are unnecessary.
- For very small slings a dish can be impractical, so keep one corner of the substrate lightly damp instead, and offer water droplets on the enclosure wall.
- Overflowing the dish deliberately is also how most keepers manage humidity, which is page 8.

Reading the abdomen

The abdomen is the fuel gauge, and it tells you about hydration and condition at a glance. Learn what your spider's looks like when it is well.

ABDOMEN	WHAT IT MEANS
Plump, smooth, roughly the size of the carapace or larger	Well fed and hydrated. This is the target
Plump and noticeably darker, with a bald patch on top	Premolt. Normal, and it means stop feeding (page 13)
Smaller than the carapace but smooth	Lean. Offer food; if it is refused and the spider is otherwise fine, this is likely premolt
Shrunken, wrinkled, raisin-like	Dehydration. Act now, page 24. This can be fatal within days
Shrivelled with legs curling beneath the body	The death curl. A genuine emergency and the end stage of the above (page 24)

THE HABIT THAT PREVENTS MOST OF THIS BOOK

Look at the water dish every single day, and top it up. It takes three seconds, it is the whole of the daily routine on page 34, and it prevents the leading cause of death in captive tarantulas. Nothing else in this package has that ratio of effort to consequence.

Diet & feeding by life stage

Live insect prey, no formulated diet, and a schedule that matters much less than most keepers expect.

STAGE	FEEDING
Sling under about 2 in (5 cm)	Every 2 to 3 days, on pinhead crickets, fruit flies, or other tiny prey no larger than the sling's own abdomen. Pre-killed prey is fine and often easier at this size
Juvenile roughly 2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm)	Sources disagree most here: estimates run from every 4 to 7 days up to every 7 to 14. Growth is slowing, so treat any figure as a starting point and adjust on abdomen size and appetite
Subadult and adult	Commonly every 1 to 2 weeks, but the real need is strongly species-dependent. A slow-metabolism species like a Chilean rose hair may want four or five crickets a month; a fast-growing tropical species can eat several times a week
Mature male	After the final molt into maturity many eat markedly less or stop almost entirely, redirecting energy toward finding a mate. Some never eat again. This is a natural end-of-life pattern, not a health problem (page 27)
Premolt, any age	Stop feeding entirely. A live cricket in with a soft, freshly molted spider is a genuine killer (page 14)

TWO RULES THAT APPLY AT EVERY STAGE

Prey should be **no larger than the tarantula's own abdomen**, and any uneaten prey comes out **within 24 hours**. A live cricket left in the enclosure will chew on a tarantula, and a spider approaching a molt cannot defend itself. This is not a hypothetical: it is one of the commonest avoidable deaths in the hobby.

How a tarantula eats

It injects digestive enzymes through its fangs to liquefy the prey's insides, then a muscular sucking stomach pumps the liquid meal into the gut. What is left is a small compacted pellet of exoskeleton, called a bolus, usually deposited away from the retreat or in the water dish. Offer prey live and whole, never chopped, and remove the bolus when you see it.

Gut-loading, which is the only route in

Feed the feeder insects a nutritious diet for a day or two before offering them, so that nutrition actually reaches the spider. There is no calcium or vitamin dusting here: that is a reptile practice, and a tarantula cannot use it. Whatever the crickets or roaches have eaten is the entire nutritional content of the meal, which makes gut-loading the only lever you have.

RELEASE, DON'T PRESENT

Put the prey in and let the spider hunt it, rather than dangling it with tongs. The ambush is what the animal is built for and it is free enrichment.

VARY THE TIMING

Feed on an irregular schedule rather than the same evening each week. It costs nothing and it is the feeding variation the fish and invertebrate enrichment literature supports.

COUNT, AND LOG IT

Write down what went in and whether it was taken, on page 38. In a species that fasts for months, the log is the only way to tell a normal fast from a decline.

Prey chart & the never-feed list

Staple every feeding, occasional as variety, rare as a treat, never at all.

PREY	TIER	NOTES
Crickets	STAPLE	The default. High protein, low fat, easy to digest, and available in every size from pinhead up. Gut-load for a day or two first
Dubia or discoid roaches	STAPLE	More nutrient-dense than crickets and slower to digest. Better for larger spiders, and they don't chirp or die overnight in the tub
Mealworms	SUPPLEMENT	Useful as variety rather than a whole diet. They burrow if not taken, so offer in a shallow dish or crush the head first
Superworms	SUPPLEMENT	Crush the head before offering. They bite, and a superworm loose in the enclosure is a hazard to a molting spider
Locusts and hoppers	SUPPLEMENT	Good size range and readily taken. Same 24-hour removal rule as everything else
Waxworms	TREAT	Fine occasionally. Too fatty for regular use, and a spider offered them often may start refusing better food
Pinky mouse	RARE	Only for the largest species, and not necessary for a healthy diet at all. Messy, and the leftovers foul an enclosure fast
Wild-caught insects	NEVER	Pesticide and parasite risk that is not worth taking. Buy from a breeder or a pet shop instead
Fireflies	NEVER	Treated as a hard no across tarantula keeping. The strongest documented toxicity data is actually for reptiles, but the precaution is consistent enough to take seriously
Anything from a garden that has been sprayed	NEVER	Insecticide residue on a feeder kills a tarantula outright, and you will not know which one it was
Processed human food	NEVER	Not remotely part of the diet. There is no version of this that works
Vertebrate prey for a small species	NEVER	Size rule overrides curiosity: nothing larger than the abdomen, ever

GUT-LOADING, BRIEFLY

Feed the feeders on fresh vegetables, leafy greens, carrot, and a dry grain-based insect food for a day or two before offering them. A cricket kept in an empty tub for a week is close to an empty package, and since dusting is not an option here, that is the whole nutritional transaction.

THE 24-HOUR RULE AGAIN, BECAUSE IT MATTERS

Any prey not taken within 24 hours comes out. Crickets are omnivorous scavengers and will chew on a tarantula, particularly one that is soft after a molt or immobile in premolt. Keepers lose spiders to this every year, and it is entirely avoidable with a look in the enclosure the next evening.

Why a tarantula stops eating

This is the one pet in this series where skipping meals for weeks is genuinely normal. Here is how to tell the difference.

1. **Premolt fasting.** By far the most common reason. A darkening, plumping abdomen and reduced activity typically come first. Duration varies hugely: slings might fast a few weeks, adults can go several months, with rare outlier cases reported well past a year (page 13).
2. **Post-molt recovery.** Straight after molting the new exoskeleton and fangs are soft. Don't feed for roughly 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults (page 14).
3. **Mature male mating drive.** Once males reach their final molt, many stop eating heavily or entirely as they focus on finding a mate. Natural, not illness (page 27).
4. **A new enclosure or environmental stress.** Rehousing, or an off husbandry detail such as temperature, humidity, or no available hide, can put a spider off food for a stretch after a move (page 18).
5. **Species-specific fasting tendency.** Chilean rose hairs in particular have a reputation for long, apparently unprompted fasts with nothing else going on at all.
6. **Prey pickiness.** Refusing one prey type while accepting another, or refusing prey that is too large, is not a health concern by itself. Try a different feeder before concluding anything.
7. **Illness, injury, or dehydration.** The one that matters. Appetite loss paired with not drinking, visible injury, uncoordinated legs, or the death curl points at a real problem (page 24).

When to actually worry

Not eating by itself is usually not an emergency for a tarantula. The one concrete sourced threshold is for juveniles specifically: refusing food for more than **6 to 8 weeks alongside weight loss or lethargy** warrants a vet consult where one is available. Adults can safely fast far longer during premolt, and sources do not converge on a single number for them, with weeks to several months well within normal.

What to check, in order

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1. Is the water dish full, and has it been full the whole time? | 4. Has anything changed recently: a rehouse, a move, a temperature swing? |
| 2. Is the abdomen plump and smooth, or shrunken and wrinkled? | 5. Is the spider webbing more than usual, or sealing itself in? |
| 3. Is there a bald patch on the abdomen, and has it darkened? | 6. Is it moving normally, with all eight legs under control? |

DON'T KEEP OFFERING FOOD TO A FASTING SPIDER

Every rejected cricket left in overnight is a risk to an animal that may be about to molt. Offer, wait 24 hours, remove, and then leave it a week or two before trying again. Repeatedly restocking an enclosure with live prey because the spider "must be hungry" is how premolt fasting turns into an injury.

Molting: the cycle

A tarantula grows by shedding its whole exoskeleton, fangs and stomach lining included. It is the most dangerous thing that happens to it, and it happens over and over.

What is actually going on

An exoskeleton cannot stretch, so growth means building a new, larger one underneath the old one and then climbing out. The old cuticle separates, the spider pumps hemolymph forward to split the carapace, and it works its legs free. What comes out is soft, pale, and completely defenceless for days. The shed skin left behind, the exuvia, is a near-perfect hollow copy of the animal, right down to the fangs and the book lung linings.

Reading premolt

SIGN	WHAT IT MEANS
A bald patch on top of the abdomen	In New World species, urticating hairs have been kicked off and the patch darkens as the new cuticle forms beneath. One of the clearest early signs
The abdomen darkens, often to near-black	The new exoskeleton showing through. Reliable in most species, though hard to read on very dark spiders
Food refused, sometimes for weeks or months	Normal and expected. Stop offering rather than persisting (page 12)
Lethargy, sitting still for long stretches	Normal. Inactivity is nearly all of a tarantula's behavior budget anyway (page 21)
Heavy webbing, or sealing itself into the burrow	Preparation. Leave the web alone: it is a molting mat, not untidiness
Dull, faded, slightly stretched-looking colour	The old cuticle at the end of its life. Colour comes back brilliantly after the molt

How long it takes

PREMOLT

Weeks for a sling, up to several months for an adult, with rare outliers past a year. There is no way to hurry it and no reason to want to.

THE MOLT ITSELF

A few hours to most of a day. Terrestrials usually flip onto their backs to do it, which looks alarming and is entirely normal.

HARDENING

3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults, before the fangs are hard enough to eat with.

Frequency, which slows with age

A sling may molt every few weeks. A juvenile every couple of months. A mature female once or twice a year, then less often as she ages, and she keeps doing it for life. A male stops permanently at his final molt into maturity, which is why he lives four to seven years against her fifteen to twenty (page 27).

Molting: what to do and never do

THE ONE ABSOLUTE RULE IN TARANTULA KEEPING

Do not handle, disturb, move, or feed a tarantula in premolt, mid-molt, or for the hardening period afterwards. Not to check on it, not to rearrange the enclosure, not to take a photograph from a better angle. Interrupting a molt is frequently fatal and there is no way to undo it.

During premolt

Do

- Stop feeding, and remove any prey already in there immediately.
- Keep the water dish full. Hydration matters more now than at any other time, because a dehydrated spider molts badly.
- Dampen one corner of the substrate if the enclosure has run dry. Ambient moisture helps the old cuticle release.
- Leave the webbing exactly as the spider built it.
- Log the date you first saw the bald patch, on page 39. It makes the next cycle predictable.

Don't

- Don't rehouse. If the enclosure needs changing, it needed changing a month ago; wait until the spider has hardened (page 18).
- Don't mist the spider directly, ever.
- Don't "help" by pulling at the old skin. This tears limbs off.
- Don't keep offering food because it has been a while.

After the molt

1. Leave it entirely alone for the hardening window: 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults. The fangs are soft and it cannot eat, and it cannot defend itself either.
2. Keep the water dish full throughout. This is the one thing you do during hardening.
3. Offer a small prey item at the end of the window, smaller than usual. If it is refused, wait a few more days.
4. Remove the exuvia once the spider has moved away from it, and keep it if you want to sex the spider (page 27). It is the best sexing evidence you will get.
5. Log the molt date and, if you can, the new leg span, on page 39.

WHEN A MOLT GOES WRONG

A spider stuck partway out, with the old cuticle still attached to legs or fangs, is in real trouble and it is largely down to hydration and humidity. Raise ambient moisture and leave it be: intervention almost always causes more damage than the stuck molt itself, and a keeper pulling at old skin is the usual way a survivable molt becomes a fatal one. A vet who treats invertebrates is the only hand that should touch it (page 25).

Handling: why the answer is no

If you want a pet you can hold, a tarantula is the wrong choice, and it is better to know that before buying one than after.

The risk to the spider

A fall from your hand, your shoulder, or a couch cushion can rupture a tarantula's abdomen, and that is often fatal. Even a short drop, the kind that would not concern you for a moment with any other pet, can be catastrophic, because hemolymph flows freely through the body cavity rather than being contained in vessels. There is no real margin for error, which is the same reason the enclosure on page 6 is built low and wide.

The risk to you

New World species defend themselves by flicking urticating hairs, which cause skin, respiratory, and eye irritation on contact. Bites are uncommon and rarely medically serious for a healthy adult human, feeling roughly like a hornet sting, but the bigger issue is what happens next: a bite triggers a reflexive jerk or drop from the handler, which brings you straight back to the fall risk above, and often kills the spider that was only defending itself. Page 17 covers both in detail.

NEVER HANDLE

A tarantula in premolt, mid-molt, or hardening (page 14) · an Old World species, which have no urticating hairs and lean much harder on biting · a newly acquired spider you do not yet know · over a hard floor, or anywhere above waist height · when you are alone with no way to contain an escape.

What interacting actually looks like

Since handling is not the goal, the relationship is built through observation and careful maintenance instead.

What interacting actually looks like

- Observation, which is genuinely the point of this animal. A tarantula remodelling a burrow or taking prey is worth watching.
- Long tongs for rearranging decor, removing a bolus, or guiding a cup-and-lid move (page 19).
- Enclosure maintenance done without ever touching the spider.
- Wash your hands after any enclosure work, and keep them away from your face and eyes until you have.
- Keep a catch cup and a piece of card within reach whenever the enclosure is open. That is the whole escape plan.
- Move slowly. Almost every defensive response in this species is a reaction to something sudden.

Reading defensive behavior

Rearing up on the hind legs, flicking hairs toward a perceived threat, displaying the fangs, stridulating (a hissing sound made by rubbing leg bristles in some species), and simply bolting are all defensive signals. None of them mean aggression in the way that word works with a mammal. They are the responses of an animal that would much rather be left alone, and the correct answer to every one of them is to close the enclosure and come back another day.

WHO ELSE LIVES IN YOUR HOUSE

Think about children, cats, and dogs before an enclosure goes on an open shelf. A dog that noses an enclosure gets a face full of urticating hairs, and a curious child opening a lid is how a spider ends up loose and stepped on. A secure lid and a sensible location protect everyone in the room, the spider included.

THE HONEST TAKEAWAY

A tarantula is a rewarding animal to keep and a poor animal to hold. Handling adds risk for the spider and for you and returns nothing the spider wants. Keepers who have been in the hobby longest handle least, which is not a coincidence.

Urticating hairs, bites & your own safety

The most common real-world injury in tarantula keeping is not a bite. It is hairs in an eye.

Urticating hairs

Tiny barbed hairs on the abdomen, flicked off with the hind legs toward a threat. They are strictly a New World trait: Old World species, including the baboon spiders and *Poecilotheria*, never developed them and rely on bites instead, which is a large part of why they are considered a step up in risk.

WHERE	WHAT HAPPENS, AND WHAT TO DO
Skin	Itching, redness, and a rash that can persist for days or weeks. Don't scratch or rub, which drives the hairs deeper. Lift them off with sticky tape rather than washing, repeating until most are out, then wash the area. An antihistamine or hydrocortisone cream helps
Eyes	The serious one. The hairs are barbed and migrate through eye tissue, causing the granulomatous reaction called ophthalmia nodosa; a 2012 case report tracked them from the corneal surface into the eye itself. Do not rub, and do not flush: there is no documented rinse for an embedded hair. Shield the eye without pressing on it and get to an ophthalmologist or emergency department the same day. This is why you never put your face near an open enclosure
Airway	Sneezing, coughing, and irritation from airborne hairs, particularly when disturbing an enclosure a spider has flicked into. Ventilate the room and wear a dust mask for a full substrate change. Wheezing, throat tightness or real difficulty breathing is a same-day emergency room visit: severe cases have needed airway management

PROTECT YOUR EYES, SERIOUSLY

Do not lean over an open enclosure. Do not blow on a spider to move it. Wear glasses or safety glasses for a rehouse or a substrate change, especially with a species known for flicking. This is one line of prevention against the injury most likely to actually send you to a doctor.

Bites

Uncommon, and almost always the end of a chain of warnings that were ignored. For New World species commonly kept as pets, a bite is usually described as comparable to a hornet sting: painful, locally swollen, and not medically dangerous to a healthy adult. Old World species carry more potent venom, and bites from some can cause severe pain, cramping, and systemic effects lasting days.

If bitten

- Put the spider down safely first, on a low surface, before you react to the pain. This is the moment most spiders die.
- Wash the site, apply a cold pack, and take a standard painkiller.
- Seek medical attention for severe pain, spreading swelling, cramping, difficulty breathing, or any Old World bite.

Tell them what bit you

- Have the species name written down somewhere findable, including on page 30. "A tarantula" is not enough information for a clinician.
- There is no antivenom for theraphosid bites and none is needed; treatment is symptomatic.
- Allergic reactions to hairs or venom are individual. If you have had a strong reaction once, take it more seriously the next time.

Rehousing: when & how to prepare

Moving a tarantula between enclosures is the one job that genuinely requires a plan, and the whole plan is about not needing to touch it.

When to rehouse

- The spider has outgrown its enclosure, meaning the floor is no longer about three times its leg span.
- It arrived in a shipping vial or deli cup and needs a real setup.
- The substrate is fouled, mite-ridden, or moldy beyond spot-cleaning.
- You got the type wrong: a fossorial species on shallow substrate, or a terrestrial in something tall (page 7).
- **Never** in premolt, mid-molt, or during hardening. Wait it out, however long that takes (page 14).
- Not just because the enclosure looks untidy. Webbing and rearranged substrate are the animal's work, not mess.

Before you open anything

- ☐ New enclosure set up and running a few hours ahead, hide placed, water dish filled, lid to hand
- ☐ Work inside a large clear plastic tub or an empty bathtub, so an escape is contained rather than loose in a room
- ☐ Catch cup, a spare, and a stiff piece of card within reach. Long tongs, a soft brush for nudging
- ☐ Glasses or safety glasses on, for the hairs (page 17)
- ☐ Doors shut, pets out of the room, phone silenced, nobody about to walk in
- ☐ Working at a low level, near the floor, so any fall is inches rather than feet

Rehousing: the method

Slowly, low to the ground, and without your hands ever entering the enclosure.

The method

1. Open the old enclosure and wait. Do not reach in. Give the spider a minute to decide you are not a threat.
2. Place the catch cup over the spider, or in its path, and slide the card gently underneath to close it. Never scoop from above with a hand.
3. An arboreal species is a different job: bring the cup to it at its own level on the decor rather than chasing it, or move it already sealed in whatever it retreated into.
4. If the spider is in a burrow, do not dig it out. Lay the old enclosure on its side inside the new one, or place the two mouth to mouth, and let the spider walk across in its own time. This can take hours. Let it.
5. Set the sealed cup down inside the new enclosure near the hide, slide the card out, and lift the cup away. Let the spider walk out on its own. Do not tip, shake or tap it out.
6. Lid on immediately, then leave the spider entirely alone for a week. No food, no photographs, no rearranging.
7. Keep the water dish full, log the rehouse date on page 39, and expect a refused meal or two afterwards (page 12).

IF IT BOLTS

Most do, at some point, and speed is species-dependent: some walk, some are gone in a blink. Don't grab, don't chase, and don't panic: those are how spiders get injured and how keepers get bitten. Cover it with the catch cup where it stops. This is exactly why the whole job happens inside a tub with the door shut, and why nothing about it should be rushed.

NEVER

Rehouse with bare hands, tip a spider out of one enclosure into another from a height, use a mesh-lidded container as a catch cup, or attempt a rehouse when you are tired, distracted, or in a hurry. If it is not going well, close everything up and try again tomorrow. There is no deadline.

Common mistakes

Tarantula keeping is simple, and it goes wrong in a small number of very specific ways.

MISTAKE	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
Letting the water dish run dry	Chronic dehydration, the leading preventable cause of death. Nothing else on this list is as common or as easy to avoid (page 9)
A tall enclosure, or one only part-filled with substrate	Fall height. A ruptured abdomen is usually fatal because hemolymph is not contained in vessels (pages 6 and 24)
A mesh lid	Feet catch in it. A spider can tear off a leg getting free, or hang from it and drop
An obligate burrower on shallow substrate	Kept that way for visibility, which is the commonest genuine welfare failure in the hobby (page 7)
Sand as substrate	Holds no burrow, no useful moisture, and abrades. Wrong even for arid species, which live in humid burrows below a dry surface
Leaving uneaten prey in overnight	Crickets chew on a soft or immobile tarantula. Kills spiders every year, entirely avoidably (page 11)
Feeding, moving, or checking a spider in premolt	The one absolute rule in the hobby, and interrupting a molt is frequently fatal (page 14)
Reading a fast as illness	Weeks or months without food is normal here. Look at the abdomen, not the calendar (page 12)
Reading stillness as a problem, or as contentment	Inactivity was nearly all of the observed behavior in both housing conditions of the one controlled study. Stillness tells you nothing either way (page 21)
Handling for the sake of it	Adds risk to spider and keeper and returns nothing the spider wants (page 15)
Heat mat under the enclosure	Heats the substrate a spider burrows into to escape heat. Side-mounted and on a thermostat, or not at all (page 8)
Misting the enclosure heavily	Mold and mite blooms, with no benefit over a full water dish and one damp corner (page 8)
Two spiders in one enclosure	Most species are solitary and cannibalistic. No enclosure size fixes this
Buying before checking the law	A handful of places ban tarantulas outright and a couple permit only named species (page 28)

THE PATTERN UNDER ALL OF THEM

Nearly every entry is either water, fall height, or a molt. Get those three right and you have avoided most of what kills captive tarantulas, which is why they take up eight of this package's pages between them and why the daily routine on page 34 is three lines long.

Enrichment: what the one study says

There is exactly one controlled tarantula housing study, and it is unusually honest about what it did and did not find.

Stalter and colleagues published a preliminary behavioral study of Brazilian black tarantulas, *Grammostola pulchra*, in *PLoS ONE* in December 2024. A counterbalanced design compared Standard against Complex housing, Complex being roughly **six times larger with six times as many structural elements**. Four findings came out of it, and a guide that quotes only the flattering ones is not telling you the truth.

FINDING	RESULT
Activity	Did <i>not</i> change. Behavior budgets were approximately equivalent in both conditions, and inactivity accounted for nearly all observed behavior
Space use	Did change. Home ranges were 77% larger and core areas 113% larger in the complex enclosure. Given more, the spiders used more
Boldness	Changed. In a novel environment test, tarantulas had 150% greater odds of being active after living in the complex condition, which the authors read as a more neophilic response
Preference	Did <i>not</i> appear. Offered both simultaneously, the spiders showed no clear preference , splitting their time roughly evenly

The authors' own conclusion is that welfare may be improved by complexity, on the strength of the space use and novelty results, while noting plainly that broad behavior patterns were similar, no preference emerged, and the sample was small. The preference test is the one that ought to make everyone cautious: it is the closest thing to asking the animal directly, and the answer was a shrug.

Priority order

1. Substrate depth and enclosure type matched to the species

2. Water, always available

3. A retreat the spider can web into and modify

4. Correct humidity and ventilation
5. Floor area beyond the minimum, without adding fall height

6. Low structure to move through

7. Live prey released rather than presented

TWO LIMITS ON THE SPACE FINDING

An enclosure so large that a terrestrial spider can fall a significant distance is dangerous, whatever the home-range data says. And a very large enclosure makes a small spider hard to find and hard to feed. **Height is the risk, floor area is the benefit**, and that distinction is what makes the study usable rather than misleading.

Health red flags

THE HONEST SITUATION

Veterinary care for tarantulas is genuinely limited, and many areas simply do not have a vet who treats invertebrates at all. That reshapes how tarantula health works: prevention through correct husbandry does almost all of the work, and knowing what is normal versus what is actually wrong matters more than knowing what to do once something has gone wrong. This section is weighted accordingly.

Act now

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS AT
Shrunken, wrinkled, raisin-like abdomen	Dehydration. Fatal within days if not corrected (page 24)
Legs curled tightly beneath an upright body	The death curl, the end stage of the above. Emergency (page 24)
Clear fluid leaking from a joint or the abdomen	Hemolymph loss from a fall or injury. Real emergency (page 24)
Unable to lift the body off the ground	Severe dehydration or systemic failure (page 24)
Stuck partway out of a molt	Molt complication, usually hydration-driven (page 25)
Uncoordinated legs, jerky or twitching movement	Possible dyskinetic syndrome, or a pesticide exposure (page 26)
White material around the mouthparts, with appetite loss	Oral nematodes. Rare in captive-bred spiders (page 26)
Tiny moving specks on the spider or the substrate	Mites. A husbandry problem rather than an illness (page 25)
Fuzzy growth on substrate, prey remains, or the spider	Mold. Ventilation and hygiene (pages 8 and 25)
A leg missing or visibly damaged	Usually survivable, and it regrows over the next couple of molts (page 14)

What isn't a red flag, and finding a vet

Half of tarantula health is knowing which alarming-looking things are completely normal.

What is not a red flag

- Sitting motionless for days. Inactivity is nearly the whole behavior budget (page 21).
- Refusing food for weeks or months, with a plump abdomen. That is premolt (page 12).
- Lying on its back with legs folded. That is a molt in progress (page 13).
- A bald patch on the abdomen. Hairs kicked off, and an early premolt sign.
- Heavy webbing, or sealing itself into the burrow. Preparation, not distress.
- Rearranging substrate and burying the water dish. That is the animal working.

THE DISTINCTION THAT DOES THE WORK

A **plump** spider refusing food is almost always fine, and usually in premolt. A **shrivelled** spider refusing food is an emergency. Hunger is not the red flag in this species. Hydration is. Look at the abdomen before you look at the calendar.

A SPIDER ON ITS BACK IS NOT DYING

Terrestrial tarantulas molt upside down. A spider lying inverted with its legs folded is almost certainly mid-molt and must be left completely alone. The one that looks similar and means the opposite is the death curl, where the legs curl *tightly underneath* an upright body rather than splaying above an inverted one (page 24). Learn to tell those two apart before you ever need to.

DON'T READ STILLNESS AS ANYTHING AT ALL

Inactivity was nearly all of the observed behavior in both conditions. A tarantula sitting motionless for days is a tarantula. The trap runs both ways: because a still spider looks identical whether the setup is right or wrong, the husbandry has to be judged on substrate, humidity, ventilation and water rather than on how busy the animal looks.

If you do find a vet

Search for an exotics or invertebrate vet in your region now, while nothing is wrong, and write the number on page 30. Many will do a phone consult. Have ready: the species in Latin, the spider's approximate age and last molt date from page 39, the enclosure setup and its actual measured temperature and humidity, what and when it last ate, and exactly what changed. Experienced keeper communities are the realistic second line and they are genuinely useful, but they are not a diagnosis.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PRACTICE

Read page 9 again, keep the water dish full, keep the enclosure low, and never disturb a molt. Those four habits prevent more tarantula deaths than any treatment in this section can reverse, and that is not a failure of the hobby so much as an honest description of it.

Dehydration & falls

The two things most likely to kill a captive tarantula, and both are preventable with an object and a shape.

Dehydration

Cause	An empty or fouled water dish, an enclosure that has run bone dry, or a long fast in dry conditions. It is the most common issue keepers run into, and in almost every case the dish was the problem
Signs	A shrunken, wrinkled, raisin-like abdomen. Lethargy beyond the normal stillness. Later, the death curl: legs curling in tightly underneath an upright body, distinct from the splayed legs of a spider molting on its back (page 13). At the end stage the spider cannot lift its body off the ground
Response	Fill the dish immediately and make sure the spider can reach it. For a badly dehydrated spider, place it gently near the dish, or in an ICU-style setup: a small container with damp paper towel and a shallow water source, kept warm and dark. Mild cases often resolve within a day or two once water is available. Do not submerge the spider and do not force water into the mouthparts
Recovery	Often good and often fast, if caught before the death curl. Once the legs have curled the prognosis drops sharply, though recoveries do happen. Then fix the routine on page 34 so it cannot recur

Falls and trauma

Cause	A fall, usually during attempted handling or a rushed rehouse, or a climb inside an enclosure that is taller than it should be. Hemolymph flows freely through the body cavity rather than in vessels, so a rupture does not stay local
Signs	Visible clear fluid at a joint or on the abdomen, a split or dented abdomen, a leg dragging or held wrongly, or a spider that will not right itself
Response	A ruptured abdomen or visible hemolymph leak is a real emergency. Some keepers stem a minor leak with a small amount of cornstarch applied to the wound, which is the accepted field measure. Anything beyond minor bleeding needs specialist attention if you can find it, and the outcome usually depends on how fast you act. Keep the spider in a small, low, dark container on damp paper towel while you work out what is possible
Recovery	A lost or damaged leg is survivable and regrows over the next couple of molts. An abdominal rupture is frequently not. Most falls happen during handling, which is the whole argument on page 15

THE PREVENTION IS TWO SENTENCES LONG

Keep the water dish full, every day, for every species. Keep the enclosure low and mostly filled with substrate, so there is nothing to fall from. Those two habits address the leading cause of preventable death and the leading cause of fatal injury respectively, and neither costs anything.

Molt complications, mites & mold

Molt complications

A stuck or incomplete molt can be fatal. The best prevention is maintaining proper humidity and, critically, never disturbing or feeding a tarantula during a molt. If a spider is stuck partway out, raise ambient moisture and leave it alone: intervention almost always causes more damage than the stuck molt itself, and pulling at old skin tears off limbs. Once a molt completes, wait for the exoskeleton to harden fully, 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles and 7 to 14 for adults, before offering food (page 14).

EXPECT IT TO LOOK WRONG FOR A WHILE

A freshly molted tarantula is pale, glossy, slightly translucent, and moves clumsily. Colour and confidence both come back over the following week, and the spider is usually noticeably bigger and much more vivid than before. A lost leg regrows over the next couple of molts, which is one of the genuinely remarkable things about this animal.

Mites

Tiny moving specks on the substrate, around prey remains, or on the spider itself. This is a husbandry issue rather than an illness in the traditional sense: grain mites bloom on uneaten prey and damp, poorly ventilated substrate. Improving ventilation and enclosure sanitation resolves most cases. Remove boluses and uneaten prey promptly, and if a bloom is established, a full substrate change and a rehouse into a clean enclosure is the reliable fix (page 19).

Mold

Fuzzy growth on the substrate surface, on leftover prey, or in a damp corner. Same category and same answer: more ventilation, less misting, prompt removal of prey remains. Cross-ventilation matters more than any product here (page 8). A persistently moldy enclosure needs its substrate replaced rather than treated.

Nematodes, DKS & pesticides

The rare conditions, and the household hazard that kills a well-kept spider with no warning.

Oral nematodes

Show up as white material around the mouthparts along with decreased appetite. Rare in captive-bred spiders, and genuinely uncommon overall. It can be treated by a vet under anaesthesia where one is available, which is a meaningful caveat in this hobby. Isolate the spider from any others and do not share tongs or water dishes between enclosures.

Dyskinetic syndrome (DKS)

A poorly understood condition causing a loss of motor coordination: jerky, uncoordinated movement, twitching legs, and an inability to right itself. There is no well-established treatment and it is often fatal. Because the presentation overlaps with pesticide exposure, it is worth checking hard for a source: an insecticide-treated feeder, a flea treatment used on a pet in the same room, a cleaning spray used near the enclosure, or a plug-in insect killer anywhere in the house. Move the spider to a clean enclosure with fresh substrate and water, keep it dark and undisturbed, and remove any suspected source from the room.

THE THING THAT ISN'T A HEALTH PROBLEM

A tarantula that stops eating for weeks is very often just entering premolt. This is completely normal and not a sign of illness, and it is the single most common false alarm in the hobby. That said, refusal for more than a month, or refusal alongside dehydration signs, is worth investigating properly, whether through a specialist vet or an experienced keeper community (page 12).

PESTICIDES, WHICH DESERVE THEIR OWN WARNING

Tarantulas are invertebrates, and every insecticide in your home is designed to kill invertebrates. No bug spray in the room, no plug-in insect killers, no flea or tick treatment on a pet nearby, no ant powder along the skirting, no wild-caught feeders from ground that might have been sprayed. **A total release fogger, a bug bomb, is worse than all of them:** it fills a room with insecticide, the EPA instruction is that every pet leaves the treated space, and a tank cannot. A closed lid does not help, because the room's air becomes the tank's air. The honest caveat is that this toxicology is documented in insects and extended to arachnids on shared nerve chemistry rather than a study anyone has run. It is still one of the few ways a well-kept spider dies suddenly with no warning.

Sexing, growth & lifespan

Sex decides how long you have this animal, and the difference is not small: fifteen to twenty years against four to seven.

Why it matters so much

Female tarantulas keep molting throughout their entire adult lives, unlike most invertebrates, which stop at maturity. Males stop molting for good once they mature, and that is the mechanism behind the lifespan gap. A mature male also changes behavior: he becomes restless, wanders, often stops eating, and develops swollen palpal bulbs and, in many species, tibial hooks on the front legs. From that final molt he typically has months to a couple of years.

METHOD	HOW RELIABLE
The exuvia shed skin	The best evidence you will get at home. Flatten the abdominal skin, wet it, and look between the front pair of book lungs for a spermatheca: a flap or fold present in females and absent in males. Keep every molt until you are sure (page 14)
Ventral sexing	Looking at the epigastric furrow from underneath, through the base of a clear container. Suggestive at best, unreliable on juveniles and dark species, and widely over-trusted
Mature male features	Conclusive but very late: swollen palpal bulbs and tibial hooks appear only at the final molt, by which point most of his life is over
What the seller says	Reliable for a sexed adult from a reputable breeder. Slings are usually sold unsexed, and anyone confidently sexing a tiny sling by eye is guessing

Growth

Growth happens only at a molt, in visible steps rather than gradually. Rate depends far more on species and temperature than on how much you feed, and power-feeding a spider to grow it faster shortens a female's life without making her healthier. A sling may double in size over a few molts; an adult female may gain very little per molt and molt only once a year or less.

Measuring

- Leg span, diagonally from front leg tip to opposite rear leg tip, is the standard measure. Measure the exuvia rather than the spider.
- Log every molt date and span on page 39. Over years this becomes the only real record of the animal's life.

Lifespan by sex

- Females: commonly 15 to 20 years, and longer in some species. A genuine decades-long commitment.
- Males: typically 4 to 7 years in total, most of it pre-maturity.

BUY A SEXED ADULT FEMALE IF LONGEVITY IS THE POINT

It costs more than an unsexed sling and it removes the coin flip. If you want the animal for twenty years, that is the purchase that gets you there, and it also skips the fragile sling stage. Buying a sling is cheaper, more interesting to watch grow, and a roughly even chance of a pet that matures and dies in five years.

Where tarantulas are not legal

Almost nowhere in the United States is there a law about tarantulas. That sounds like good news, and mostly it is, but it is worth understanding why.

State wildlife codes usually define the animals they govern, and most of those definitions read something like "any wild mammal, bird, fish, reptile or amphibian." A spider is none of those things. So a tarantula is not so much permitted in those states as invisible to them, which is a different thing, and it fails in a specific way: it holds right up until a state writes a broader definition, and a handful have.

WHERE	STATUS	WHY
New York City	BANNED	The Health Code names tarantulas outright under venomous spiders
Hawaii	BANNED	No theraphosid appears on any of the four lists, and anything unlisted is prohibited by default
Montana	BANNED	A white-list state. The arachnid rule clears two scorpions and no spiders at all
District of Columbia	BANNED	A closed list of seven permitted categories, none of them invertebrate
Maine	THREE SPECIES	Brazilian black, Chaco golden knee and Chilean rose are unrestricted. Every other tarantula needs a permit
Rhode Island	PERMIT	The invertebrate exemption is written for the class Insecta, and spiders are not insects
Idaho	UNCLEAR	Wildlife is defined as any form of animal life, but the conventional-pets exemption lists no invertebrate
Arkansas	UNCLEAR	The unrestricted list has no invertebrate section in either direction
Most other states	LEGAL	The wildlife definition stops at vertebrates, so nothing reaches a spider

CHECK THREE LEVELS, NOT ONE

State law is only the first. A city or county can ban what the state permits, which is exactly what New York City does. And a lease or an HOA agreement can prohibit an animal that is perfectly legal where you live, which is the level that actually catches most keepers out. Read all three before buying, not after.

ALSO WORTH KNOWING

Many tarantula species are listed under CITES Appendix II, which governs international trade rather than private keeping, so buying captive-bred from a domestic breeder avoids the question entirely and is better for wild populations besides. Shipping live invertebrates across state or national borders has its own rules independent of whether keeping one is legal at either end. This page is a starting point and a snapshot, not legal advice: confirm current local rules yourself before you buy.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Horizontal enclosure, floor about 3× the leg span
- ☐ Total height under about 12 in (30 cm) for a terrestrial
- ☐ Secure acrylic lid with drilled holes, never mesh
- ☐ Cross-ventilation: holes on opposite sides, not only the lid
- ☐ Coconut fiber, peat, or pesticide-free soil, never sand
- ☐ At least 3 in (7.5 cm) of substrate, half to two-thirds full
- ☐ Cork bark hide, laid flat for a terrestrial, vertical for an arboreal
- ☐ Shallow water dish, and a spare
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer at substrate level
- ☐ Long feeding tongs, a catch cup, and a stiff piece of card
- ☐ Feeder insects, plus something to gut-load them on
- ☐ Safety glasses, for rehousing and substrate changes

Targets

TARGET	FIGURE
Temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), room temperature
Humidity	40 to 75% depending on the source and species; a full water dish does most of the work
Substrate depth	3 in (7.5 cm) minimum, far more for a burrower
Enclosure floor	About 3× the leg span, roughly 20×10×10 in (50×25×25 cm) for an adult
Prey size	No larger than the tarantula's own abdomen
Prey removal	Within 24 hours, every time
Feeding interval	Slings every 2 to 3 days, adults every 1 to 2 weeks, none in premolt
Post-molt fast	3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 days for adults
Occupancy	One spider per enclosure, always

Emergency & quick targets

ACT NOW IF

The abdomen is shrunken, wrinkled, or raisin-like · the legs are curled tightly beneath an upright body · clear fluid is leaking from a joint or the abdomen · the spider cannot lift its body off the ground · it is stuck partway out of a molt · its movement is jerky or uncoordinated · there is white material around the mouthparts · a leg is dragging after a fall

DO NOT ACT ON ANY OF THESE

Sitting motionless for days · refusing food for weeks or months with a plump abdomen · lying on its back with legs folded, which is a molt · a bald patch on the abdomen · heavy webbing or sealing itself in · burying the water dish

READING	TARGET
Temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Water dish	Full, every day, no exceptions
Prey size	No larger than the abdomen
Prey removal	Within 24 hours
In premolt	No food, no handling, no rehousing, no disturbance

Your details

Species, in Latin _____ Sex, and how confirmed _____
 Exotics or invertebrate vet _____ Last molt date _____
 Acquired on, and from _____ Current leg span _____

IF YOU ARE BITTEN

Put the spider down safely on a low surface first, before reacting to the pain. Wash the site, apply a cold pack, take a standard painkiller. Seek medical attention for severe pain, spreading swelling, cramping, difficulty breathing, or any Old World species bite, and tell them the species name from the line above. Hairs in an eye: do not rub, flush with saline, and get seen the same day.

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear, the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Enclosure, horizontal, with an acrylic vented lid	\$20 to \$80
Substrate: coconut fiber, peat, or pesticide-free soil	\$10 to \$30
Cork bark hide, plus decor	\$15 to \$45
Shallow water dish, and a spare	\$5 to \$15
Long feeding tongs	\$8 to \$15
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$10 to \$25
Catch cup, card, and a large tub to rehouse inside	\$8 to \$20
Safety glasses	\$5 to \$15
First feeder insects, plus gut-load food	\$8 to \$20
Equipment subtotal	\$89 to \$265
The tarantula, beginner species	\$25 to \$100
All-in before the spider arrives	\$114 to \$365

A Chilean rose hair or curly hair typically runs \$20 to \$50, and spiderlings cost less than adults. A sexed adult female costs more and removes the coin flip on lifespan (page 27).

ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Feeder insects, crickets or dubia roaches	\$5 to \$15 a month
Substrate replacement, once or twice a year	\$1 to \$3 a month averaged
Annual total	\$60 to \$180

That range depends mostly on the size and appetite of your particular spider. There is no pet insurance for tarantulas, and veterinary care is genuinely rare, so this is not a species where you budget for regular vet visits.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The enclosure shape and the substrate depth, because between them they are the fall risk. Everything else on this list is cheap and replaceable. Spend on getting the box right and on enough substrate to fill it properly, and save on decor. A small emergency fund is still worth having, but it is a much smaller consideration here than with almost any other pet.

First 30 days checklist

Most of this list is a set of things not to do, which is a fair description of tarantula keeping generally.

Before day 1

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up and settled: substrate in and packed, hide placed, water dish filled
- ☐ Species and type confirmed, and the enclosure matched to it (page 7)
- ☐ Legality checked at state, city and lease level (page 28)

Day 1

- ☐ Rehouse from the shipping container using the cup-and-card method, low to the ground and inside a tub (page 19)
- ☐ Lid on, lights off, and leave the spider entirely alone. No food, no photographs
- ☐ Fill in the details on page 30, and the acquisition entry on page 39
- ☐ Ask the seller for the last molt date and the last feeding date, and write both down

Week 1

- ☐ Top up the water dish daily. That is the entire daily routine
- ☐ Offer one appropriately sized prey item at the end of the week. A refusal now is completely ordinary
- ☐ Note the abdomen's normal size and shape while it is healthy, ideally with a photograph (page 9)
- ☐ Check the temperature and humidity readings once, and confirm nothing is drying out

Week 2 to 4

- ☐ Settle into the feeding interval from page 10, removing anything uneaten within 24 hours
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 38, recording what went in and whether it was taken
- ☐ Leave the webbing and any rearranged substrate exactly as the spider has left it
- ☐ Watch for a darkening abdomen and a bald patch: your first premolt may arrive within weeks (page 13)

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Compare the abdomen against your week 1 photograph and adjust feeding accordingly
- ☐ Keep the first exuvia and try sexing it, then log the result on page 39 (page 27)
- ☐ Find out whether any exotics vet within reach will see an invertebrate, and write it on page 30
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 37 before you need it, and read page 36 before travelling

Symptom quick reference

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Shrunken, wrinkled, raisin-like abdomen	Dehydration	Fill the dish now, ICU setup if severe (page 24)
Legs curled tightly beneath an upright body	Death curl, advanced dehydration	Emergency. Water access immediately (page 24)
On its back, legs splayed and folded	Molting. Normal	Nothing. Do not touch, do not feed (page 13)
Clear fluid at a joint or on the abdomen	Hemolymph loss from a fall	Cornstarch on a minor leak, specialist if worse (page 24)
Stuck partway out of a molt	Molt complication, usually hydration	Raise humidity and leave alone. Do not pull (page 25)
Jerky, uncoordinated movement, twitching	DKS, or pesticide exposure	Clean enclosure, hunt for a pesticide source (page 26)
White material around the mouthparts	Oral nematodes	Isolate, don't share equipment, vet if available (page 26)
Tiny moving specks on spider or substrate	Mites	Ventilation and hygiene, then a substrate change (page 25)
Fuzzy growth on substrate or prey remains	Mold	More ventilation, less misting, remove remains (page 8)
Refusing food, abdomen plump, bald patch	Premolt. Normal	Stop offering food. Keep water full (page 13)
Refusing food, abdomen shrunken	Dehydration, not fasting	Treat as page 24, not as page 12
Mature male: restless, wandering, not eating	Mating drive after the final molt	Normal end-of-life pattern. Nothing to fix (page 27)
Sitting motionless for days on end	Being a tarantula	Nothing. Judge the setup, not the activity (page 21)
Rearing up, flicking hairs, showing fangs	Defensive display	Close the enclosure and come back another day (page 15)
Leg missing or damaged	Injury, often from a fall or a cricket	Usually survivable. It regrows over a molt or two (page 14)
Buried the water dish, webbed up the hide	Normal remodelling	Dig the dish out, refill it, leave the web (page 7)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

The shortest routine in this series, and the daily part is the part that matters.

Daily

- ☐ Look at the water dish and top it up. This is the whole daily job and it prevents the leading cause of death
- ☐ Look at the spider. Where it is, what shape the abdomen is, whether it is moving normally
- ☐ If prey went in yesterday, take out whatever is left

Weekly

- ☐ Feed on the interval for the spider's stage, unless it is in premolt (page 10)
- ☐ Remove any bolus, shed skin, or prey remains you can reach with tongs
- ☐ Read the thermometer and hygrometer rather than guessing
- ☐ Log feeding, refusals, and anything noticed on page 38
- ☐ Check the abdomen against its normal, and check for a bald patch or darkening

Monthly

- ☐ Dampen a corner of the substrate if the enclosure has dried out
- ☐ Check the lid still seats properly and the ventilation holes are clear
- ☐ Spot-clean: mold, prey remains, anything fouling the surface
- ☐ Scrub the water dish properly rather than just refilling it

Every 6 to 12 months

- ☐ Full substrate change, timed well away from a molt, using the rehousing method on page 19
- ☐ Reassess enclosure size against the spider's current leg span

Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: watch for the enclosure sitting above 80°F (27°C) in a hot room, and never in direct sun
- ☐ Winter: dry indoor heating pulls humidity down fast. Check the dish more often, not less
- ☐ Any season: no insecticide, plug-in bug killer, or pet flea treatment anywhere in the room (page 26)

Per molt

- ☐ Log the date, keep the exuvia, try sexing it, and record the new leg span (page 39)

Power outages & the blackout plan

A tarantula needs nothing running to survive, so a blackout is a temperature question and very little else.

When the power goes out

Do

- Essentially nothing. No filter, no pump, usually no heater, so a blackout is a temperature question only. The target is the room range on page 8, 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C); the University of Illinois puts the comfortable span a little wider, 70 to 85°F.
- In a cold outage, move the enclosure to the warmest room and wrap it in a towel, leaving the ventilation clear.
- In a hot outage, move it to the coolest room, out of any sun, and keep the water dish full.
- Check the dish, since a warm room evaporates it faster than usual.

Don't

- Don't add a heat source you cannot regulate. A tarantula cannot walk away from an unthermostatted mat.
- Don't open the enclosure to check on the spider by torchlight. Leave it shut.
- Don't feed. A cold spider digests slowly, and an outage is not the moment to have prey loose in there.

OUTAGE KIT

A towel, a torch, and a bottle of water for the dish. That is genuinely all of it.

Travel, transport & moving

The easiest animal in this series to leave alone, and one of the easiest to move badly.

Leaving town

WHAT DECIDES IT	WHY
Water, not food	The binding constraint, and the easy one to solve. Fill the dish the morning you leave. The University of Illinois has keepers topping it up daily in a normal week, so a visit while you are away is for the dish rather than the spider
Missed meals do not count	The same source calls the refusal before a molt a normal physiologic fast, and feeds a healthy adult a few times a week rather than daily
Feed before, not on the day	A few days ahead rather than the morning you go, and never leave live prey loose in the enclosure with nobody watching
Slings are the exception	A small spider dries out faster and eats more often. Shorten every interval and get someone in sooner

No day count is printed here on purpose: the hobby figures for how long a tarantula is fine alone do not trace to a source that will stand behind them. The reasoning is the durable part.

Transport and moving

- A small, ventilated deli cup or vial, packed snugly with crumpled paper towel or moss. Small and tight is safer than roomy: the abdomen is thin cuticle with none of the reinforcement the legs have, a fall can rupture it, and that is close to unsurvivable. Less room means less momentum.
- No water dish in transit, which sloshes and soaks. Slightly damp paper towel handles hydration for a journey.
- Keep the container upright, insulated in a padded box or cooler, out of direct sun, and never in a car boot or a parked car. Do not feed for 24 to 48 hours before travelling.
- Never transport a spider in premolt, mid-molt, or hardening. Postpone the journey if you can, and if you cannot, accept that the risk is real (page 14).
- Moving house: transport the spider separately in a travel cup rather than in its enclosure, which will shift its substrate and can crush it. Set the enclosure up fully at the new place, then rehouse the spider into it (page 19) and leave it alone for a week. Expect a refused meal or two.

SHIPPING

Start with the rule most people do not know: **USPS will not carry it.** Its mailing standards make all spiders nonmailable, with a narrow scorpion exception for medical research and antivenin, which is why the hobby ships through other carriers' live-animal programs. Check that carrier's current terms yourself. Two federal frameworks can also apply by species: USDA APHIS permits for interstate movement of plant-feeding invertebrates, and the Lacey Act injurious wildlife list. Beyond the law, live invertebrates ship in insulated boxes with heat or cold packs to season, overnight, never over a weekend. Buying, ask the seller their live-arrival policy and when they ship.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

There is very little to do here, and the most useful instruction on this page is to leave the spider alone.

Spider's name, and species _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Feed on these dates, if any _____

Where the feeders are _____

Exotics vet, if there is one _____

Each visit

- ☐ **Top up the water dish.** This is the important one, and often the only thing that needs doing. Lift the lid, pour carefully, close the lid.
- ☐ Find the spider and check it is upright and looks normal. It may be inside its hide or burrow, and that is fine.
- ☐ Make sure the lid is properly closed before you leave the room.
- ☐ Feeding, only if I have marked a date: drop in _____, then take out anything not eaten the next day.
- ☐ Wash your hands afterwards, and don't touch your face or eyes until you have.
- ☐ Keep the enclosure out of direct sun, and don't move it near a radiator.

Please don't

- Touch the spider, or put your hand in the enclosure for any reason. Use the tongs if something must come out.
- Lean your face over the open enclosure. It can flick irritating hairs, and hairs in an eye is a real injury.
- Feed extra, or feed on an unmarked day. This animal genuinely does not need it.
- Mist or spray anything into the enclosure.
- Tidy up the webbing, the rearranged soil, or a buried water dish. That is the spider's own work.
- Worry if it has not moved. Sitting still for days is completely normal for this animal.

CALL ME IF

Its belly looks shrivelled or wrinkled, like a raisin · its legs are curled up tightly underneath it · there is any clear fluid leaking from it · it is lying on its back (which is usually a normal moult, but tell me anyway and **do not touch it**) · it looks half out of an old skin and stuck · it is moving in a jerky, uncoordinated way · it has escaped · the enclosure is cracked, or the lid will not close properly

You cannot weigh a tarantula meaningfully at home and it will not tell you anything, so the record of what it ate and what its abdomen looked like is the entire clinical history. When a spider has refused food for two months, the log is what tells you whether that is the fourth premolt in three years or something new. In an animal that may outlive a car, that record is worth keeping properly.

Acquisition & molt log

Acquisition record

DETAIL	VALUE
Species, in Latin, and common name	
Type: terrestrial, fossorial, or arboreal	
Acquired from, and on what date	
Sex, and how it was confirmed	
Leg span and last molt date at purchase	

Molt log

The most valuable page in this book over a twenty-year life. Keep the exuvia until you have sexed it.

PREMOLT SEEN	MOLT DATE	NEW LEG SPAN	FED AGAIN ON	NOTES: COMPLICATIONS, SEXING, COLOUR

Equipment & maintenance log

Equipment & maintenance log

TASK	LAST DONE	DUE	DONE
Full substrate change, every 6 to 12 months			
Water dish scrubbed			
Enclosure size reassessed against leg span			
Rehousing, with the date and how it went			

Twelve-month planner

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Spot-clean and check the lid	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Scrub the water dish	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Substrate change	☐						☐					

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Substrate depth and enclosure type matched to the species (page 7)
- ☐ Water dish, always full, every species including arid ones
- ☐ A retreat the spider can web into and modify
- ☐ Floor area beyond the minimum, with no added fall height
- ☐ Low structure to move through: cork flats, leaf litter, moss, all anchored

Monthly review

- ☐ Leave anything the spider has built. Only reposition what it has ignored
- ☐ Release live prey rather than presenting it with tongs, and vary the timing
- ☐ Check nothing has shifted or can fall onto the spider
- ☐ Judge the setup on substrate, humidity, ventilation and water, not on how active the spider looks

Enrichment log

DATE	WHAT CHANGED	WHAT THE SPIDER DID WITH IT

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't keep an obligate burrower on shallow substrate for the sake of visibility. Don't give a terrestrial species height it can fall from. Don't let the water dish run dry. Don't leave live prey in with a premolt spider. Don't handle, since the risk to the spider from a fall is far greater than the risk to you. And don't treat a motionless tarantula as evidence of anything at all, in either direction (page 21).

REFERENCE

Glossary

Arboreal	Tree-dwelling. Needs height, a vertical cork slab to web a tube against, and better cross-ventilation than a terrestrial species.
Bolus	The compacted pellet of empty exoskeleton left after a meal. Remove it when you see it.
Carapace	The hard plate covering the top of the front body section. A useful size reference for judging the abdomen against.
Death curl	Legs curled tightly beneath an upright body. The end stage of dehydration and a genuine emergency. Not to be confused with a spider molting on its back.
DKS	Dyskinetic syndrome: a poorly understood loss of motor coordination, often fatal, with no established treatment. Overlaps with pesticide exposure.
Exuvia	The shed exoskeleton left behind after a molt, complete down to the fangs and book lung linings. The best sexing evidence available at home.
Fossorial	Obligate burrowing. Needs deep, firm substrate and will rarely be seen. Keeping one shallow for visibility is a welfare failure.
Gut-loading	Feeding the feeder insects well before offering them. The only route nutrition has into a tarantula, since dusting does not work here.
Hemolymph	The invertebrate equivalent of blood. It flows freely through the body cavity rather than in vessels, which is why an abdominal rupture is so often fatal.
ICU setup	A small container with damp paper towel and shallow water, kept warm and dark, used to rehydrate a badly dehydrated spider.
New World / Old World	The Americas versus Africa and Asia. New World species have urticating hairs; Old World species do not and rely on bites, which makes them a step up in risk.
Palpal bulbs	The swollen ends of a mature male's pedipalps, used to transfer sperm. Together with tibial hooks, they are conclusive proof of a mature male.
Premolt	The period before a molt: a darkening, plumping abdomen, a bald patch, refused food, and heavy webbing. Weeks for a sling, months for an adult.
Rehousing	Moving a spider between enclosures, using a catch cup and card rather than hands, low to the ground, inside a larger container.
Sling	A spiderling. Under about 2 in (5 cm), fed more often, and more fragile than an adult in every respect.
Spermatheca	The internal structure visible in a female's exuvia between the front pair of book lungs. Present in females, absent in males.
Stridulation	A hissing sound some species make by rubbing leg bristles together. A defensive warning, like the rest of the display repertoire.
Sucking stomach	The muscular pump that draws the liquefied meal in after the enzymes have done their work outside the body.
Terrestrial	Ground-dwelling. The default and the beginner group: wide, low, and mostly full of substrate.
Urticating hairs	Barbed abdominal hairs flicked at a threat, causing skin, airway, and eye irritation. Hairs in an eye are the most common real injury in this hobby.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary and scientific sources

- Stalter L et al. Tarantula welfare may be improved with greater environmental complexity: a preliminary behavioral study with Brazilian black tarantulas (*Grammostola pulchra*). *PLoS ONE* 19(12): e0314501, 2024, and its published correction. The source for all four findings on page 21.
- University of Illinois College of Veterinary Medicine, Caring for Pet Tarantulas. The temperature range on pages 8 and 35, the feeding frequency, the daily water dish, and the normal physiologic fast before a molt behind page 36.
- NIH StatPearls, Tarantula Spider Toxicity, for the urticating hair and bite guidance on page 17, including the tape removal and the eye-shield instruction.
- Mangat & Newman. Tarantula hair keratitis. *New Zealand Medical Journal*, 2012. The barbed structure, the migration through ocular tissue, and ophthalmia nodosa. Page 17.
- National Capital Poison Center, on tarantula and scorpion bites and stings.
- National Pesticide Information Center fact sheets on pyrethrins, imidacloprid and fipronil, and the US EPA on total release foggers. Page 26.
- USPS Domestic Mail Manual sections 525.4 and 526.5, USDA APHIS, and the US Fish and Wildlife Service injurious wildlife list. The shipping position on page 36.
- Tarantulas in captivity: raising and breeding. Springer.
- Tree of Life Exotic Pet Medical Center, tarantula care, for the husbandry and feeding figures in Section 02.
- Vet Verified, common health issues in pet tarantulas, for Section 03.

Husbandry references

- The Tarantula Collective, *Grammostola rosea* care sheet, for the enclosure and substrate figures on pages 6 and 7.
- Tom's Big Spiders, tarantula feeding and how much to feed, for the intervals on page 10.
- Giant Spiders, common ailments, and Tarantula Heaven on feeding refusal, for pages 12 and 24.
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the tarantula tank setup, feeding, health issues, handling, cost, enrichment and legal guides, plus the cross-species invertebrate rehousing, pesticide hazards, emergency and travel, and molting guides.

WHAT THIS PACKAGE WILL NOT PRINT

Two numbers were removed at 2.2 rather than sourced. There is no day count for how long a tarantula is safe alone on page 36, because the hobby figures trace to nothing that will stand behind them, and no rinse step for a hair in the eye on page 17, because no clinical source describes one.

Where a figure is missing here, it is missing on purpose.

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed, and when, so an older printout can be placed.

Version history

VERSION	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
2.2 · Sep 2026	t3	Cross-checked against the September 2026 cross-species invertebrate articles. Page 17's eye first aid was wrong: it told you to flush, and no clinical source describes a rinse for an embedded hair. It now says shield the eye and get same-day ophthalmology, and the airway row gained the emergency-room trigger it was missing. Page 19 slides the card rather than tipping the spider out, and gained an arboreal variant. Page 26 gained total release foggers and the honest note that the toxicology is insect data extended to arachnids. Page 35 prints a temperature. Page 36 lost its trip-length day counts, which no source supports, and gained the abdomen-rupture mechanism and the USPS prohibition on mailing spiders. Sources and version history split onto their own pages.
2.1 · Sep 2026	t3	Line spacing and table padding tightened across every page, which changed no words and no type sizes. Minimum page headroom went from 19px to 31px. No content differs from 2.0.
2.0 · Sep 2026	t3	Rebuilt on the t3 package template at 43 pages, adapted to an invertebrate layout: the reptile heat, UVB and thermostat pages replaced with a single temperature and ventilation page, and the freed space given to two pages on molting, a page on water alone, a rehousing method, urticating hair and bite first aid, sexing and lifespan, and a legality page. Adds both units throughout and reports the one controlled housing study with all four of its findings.
1.0 · Sep 2026	pre-t3	First edition, on the earlier 22-page package layout.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources on page 43 and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an exotics veterinarian who treats invertebrates, and nothing in it should delay professional advice where it is available. The legality and shipping pages are a starting point and a snapshot, not legal advice. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

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